

The unfriendly penguin?

Dear Karan

I find your editorial in the January issue quite shocking. Please allow me to explain. You have mentioned that Linux is not user-friendly! While this might be true for certain distributions, this definitely does not apply to Mandrake, SuSE and others. There are several other things that need to be considered, such as all the bundled applications—office suites, development tools and even games—that accompany these flavours. Even Windows XP doesn't give you many of these applications. And Linux is friendlier when it comes to working on other OSes. While XP might be an improvement compared to earlier versions of Windows, it comes with its own baggage of bugs and away newcomers from Linux by describing it as an unfriendly OS. Linux is something that they can find interesting and useful if they give it some time. And you guys would do both Linux and the common man a favour by carrying a Linux distribution on your CD like you have done in the past.

DINKAR

Via e-mail



Shifting OSS

Dear Sir,

Thanks for the comprehensive article on Windows XP. The article was quite detailed and touched almost every aspect of the new OS. However you missed out on the most essential part—the installation of Windows XP—that is, the hardware device drivers' compatibility issues of XP. You seemed to have written the article only for people buying new branded computers which will come with Windows XP preloaded. There was no mention of the scenarios that a person may encounter if he decides to switch from an existing Windows 98/Me installation to XP.

I hope that my suggestions will be incorporated in future issues of Digit.

ANURAG JAITLEY

Via e-mail

digit

Dear Anurag,

The reason that we haven't discussed any driver compatibility issues when it comes to XP is because we haven't yet faced any major problems due to it. During the fresh installations of Windows XP on our test machines, all the hardware was detected easily and without any glitches whatsoever. Most mainstream hardware manufacturers have already made Windows XP drivers available, which should ensure that problems will occur only with older hardware for which driver updates are no longer available.

digit

Dinkar,

If Linux wants to become popular, it has to become easier to use for the majority of computer users. The statement, if you really love Linux you will learn how to use the command prompt, just doesn't wash. People use what they are comfortable with, and Windows is still the easiest OS to get comfortable with. Windows 95 was an improvement over Windows 3.11 when it came to usability. While

installation and configuration is considerably simpler now, there is still much that needs to be done. Windows XP is a step ahead in usability and none of the Linux distributions approach that level yet. The advantage Linux has over Windows in features will, hopefully, be matched by innovations in the area of user interface. The sooner this happens, the greater the chances of Linux being of wider appeal to desktop computer users.

Is Microsoft really the bad guy?

Hey Karan,

Perhaps the title of your editorial 'Is Microsoft's domination really unjust?' should be 'Doesn't Linux need another chance?'. We have the choice to say no to Microsoft. The fact is the same people who ridicule Microsoft and call it a dictator go back to their desktops and boot up MS Windows. Besides, is Linux giving developers what they need? Does Linux give us a 'Visual Basic' to write easy-code and create GUIs in a snap? Does it give us the customisation of VBA to customise our applications? As for 'not-many-applications'—the real developers in the world know what's better and that's why they're not making Linux versions of their software even when they're creating Mac editions! Hiding behind 'excuses' is not going to get you guys through.

DAX PANDHI

Via e-mail

digit

Dear Dax,

While the popularity of operating systems with developers is important, developers build products on a platform for which there exists some demand from end-users. Consumers who pay for the products developed determine the popularity of an OS. But your observation that Microsoft provides a better set of development tools than Linux are right. As far as our criticism of Microsoft is concerned, we think that aiming for domination is quite all right. We do not count ourselves amongst the Anti-Microsoft brigade and criticism is restricted to areas where the quality of their products falls short. I am sure that is fair.

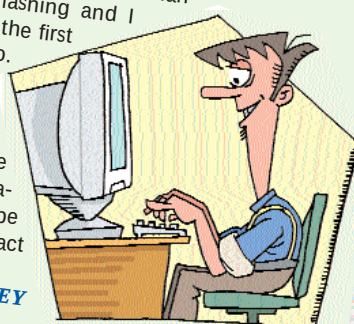
Calling Agent 001

Dear Karan,

You guys have done a great job. The January issue was smashing and I know that I'm not the first or only one to say so. I liked everything—the articles on games, processors test and even the graphics and illustrations. Digit would be nicer if we could contact Agent 001 via e-mail.

JAYANTA KUMAR DEY

Via e-mail



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Dear Jayanta,

You can ask Agent 001 your questions by visiting our Smart Buyer's Form at www.thinkdigit.com/forums. Just register at the site and you will get the buying advice you need.